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Houston Person

Houston Person is a tenor saxophonist who is equally comfortable in a jazz quartet or with an organ based trio that leans towards R&B. Born in 1934, Houston grew up in South Carolina and was fortunate to play with future jazz greats Eddie Harris and Cedar Walton while in the military. He later attended the Hartt School of Music and toured with a number of organ trios. Houston has recorded numerous albums as a leader and enjoys a long time collaboration with singer Etta Jones.

Mr. Person was interviewed by Michael Woods and Monk Rowe on May 29, 1995.

MW: We are filming interviews for the Hamilton College Jazz Archive, and my name is Dr. Michael Woods, my colleague is Monk Rowe, and today we are going to be interviewing and just conversing and relaxing and having a good time with Houston Person. We are very pleased to have you here and talk to you about your involvement in jazz.

HP: Well I'm glad to be here, I think.

MR: I think you will be.

MW: How old were you when you first started playing, and what attracted you to the music?

HP I was about 18 or 19, but I'd always been listener of jazz through my friends. Some of my friends introduced me to it, my neighbors, and hearing it on radio, and it just attracted me — the creativeness of it. And my last year in high school, my father got me an instrument for Christmas. Before that I was involved mostly in sports, and we did have a piano in the home. During that time I guess when I was coming along, every home had a piano. And my mother was a school teacher, and she played the piano, so she taught me piano at an early age, which I wasn't interested in, so I studied for about 5-6 months. And then that was real early. And that after that, much later, I got the saxophone, and that stuck, that stuck. So that's about 17 or 18, and then I went on to college and really got involved in jazz.

MR: Did you go to the Hartt School of Music?

HP: Yes. I went to South Carolina State College first. I went there for three years. Then I went in the service, and then came back and went to Hartt School of Music. So I was kind of a school junkie during that time. I thought I'd stay in school forever.

MR: Was I correct in reading that during the military service you got to play with quite a few people that later on became good jazz musicians also?

HP: Oh, yeah, well they were great jazz musicians when I met them — Eddie Harris, Cedar Walton, Leo Wright, Don Menza.

MR: Don Menza.

HP: These guys were all great players then. I was just starting out. So they helped me a great deal in my early years, helping me get myself together and being very tolerant of course. They took me under their wings and helped me a lot. In fact, the basis of my whole playing, my approach, goes back to those guys. There was Aaron Harvey, Bobby Ephraim, in my early association with them at South Carolina State, and the South Carolina State College Band, which took me on and I didn't know a thing, they just helped me along.

MR: Were you always a tenor player?

HP: Yeah, always. I did study other instruments when I went to the conservatory, but I stuck with tenor saxophone. I just play that exclusively.

MW: You talked about them helping you form your conception. How do you feel that your voice on the tenor is different from other tenor players and other instrumentalists in general? Or what typifies your sound? What do you like?

HP: I like all kinds of music. I grew up with rhythm & blues and country & western music.

MW: Who were some of your favorite rhythm & blues artists?

HP: Roy Milton, Amos Milburn, Bull Moose Jackson. They all use jazz players, so it wasn't such finely drawn lines as there are now. Oh, man there were so many. Charles Brown. And most of these artists, you know, could be considered jazz artists also. The Ravens, The Dominoes, and all those, Sonny Till and the Orioles. So it was a lot of them, of that type. Of course there was Gospel music which I was greatly influenced by. So it's a whole cross section of a lot of things.

MW: You know basically they say that the only difference between rhythm & blues and Gospel is one guy is talking about God and the other one is talking about his girlfriend.

HP: That's right.

MW: Name me some of them Gospel groups you like.

HP: Five Blind Boys.

MW: I love the Five Blind Boys.

HP: The Southernaires.

MW: Gospel Southernaires.

HP: Some of the current ones, you know, James Cleveland, I'm mad about the Brooklyn Tabernacle Choir.

MW: Yeah.

HP: There's a lot of people out there that go unsung, you know, that we don't hear about. And I'm in to a lot of those. Jermaine Hawkins.

MW: Oh, yes.

HP: Who I think is one of the greatest singers, regardless.

MW: Oh, yes, oh yes.

HP: Oh, the Wayans, you know there are a lot of them, you know, a lot of them. And a lot of them stay in the Gospel thing, they turn down what they consider to be more of a commercial success singing secular music, but they are true, they have a lot of integrity. I admire that too.

MW: Yes, I wanted to say something about this, 'cause I think this is important, is much of the music that is emanated from the African American community started in church, in some capacity.

HP: Oh yeah, it all goes back to the church.

MW: You know, and I still sense some of that in different forms in the style, in the delivery style sometimes, of the jazz artists.

HP: Oh, yeah.

MW: The spirituality is still in there.

HP: Yeah. And as far as you hear some of the great tenor players like Illinois Jacquet, Willis Jackson and all those guys coming along there, they had that style, well I guess you'd say honking, but it's like a preacher preachin'.

MW: It sure is, it sure is.

HP: It's a call and response. In fact some of that's better than what's going on now, really, as far as getting the audience involved.

MW: The thing I always loved about Gospel music and I'd like to see it transfer into jazz is the immediate qualities and dynamics of its communication. In other words, when I listen to a guy on the Hammond B3 behind the preacher, after he gets going, you know, the whole concept of thinking about music theory is completely secondary to its power to communicate immediately.

HP: Well that's a trait in Gospel and rhythm & blues, wherein, that's the approach that I try to use, well that's the approach I use 'cause I know no other approach, is emotion first, heart first, and whether it's wrong or not, if you deliver it with authority, because when you listen to the preacher a lot of times, his grammar isn't out of Harvard, but the delivery is there, and sometimes, well it's not a critique of jazz, it's just that sometimes we don't involve the audience enough, because you've just got to sit there. And the way I remember it, my background, I shouldn't say the way I remember it, my background is people were dancing and it was more of a frolicking good time. And there was audience involvement. And if you wanted to listen you listen, and if you wanted to dance you dance. But dance is a part of jazz which we've almost taken out of it. Thus we've lost a lot of listeners too that way.

MW: You know in some West African societies, the word music and the word dance are not separate.

HP: No it's together. Well every culture has dance, I mean regardless — even opera has ballet, you know, and country music has square dancing.

MW: Line dancing.

HP: Polkas have Polish polkas, every culture has dance. Every culture has a dance associated with its music.

MR: I remember John Heard trying to define jazz for us and the only way he could describe it was it's a dance.

HP: Yeah. But when you eliminate elements, you lose some of the essence, to me, that's just to me. Now there are parts of it where, as in any culture too, where you have a music that you listen to. You go to the opera and you sit and you listen. But dance is represented in some way because you're going to have a ballet or some sort of dance. But then there are other forms of music, classical music, where you dance, like a waltz. The waltz is a lot of fun to a lot of people. But a lot of people wouldn't listen to a waltz if they couldn't dance. So a lot of people don't listen to jazz because they can't dance. I had a guy ask me just on the airplane just coming over here, he said, "can you still dance to jazz?" That's a heck of a question.

MW: I don't know that you could dance to some of the stuff Cecil Taylor does.

HP: Well I'm saying there are elements of any music where you sit and listen. There's a time for that. And then there's a time, I mean, you go to church you listen—

MW: I was just going to mention church.

HP: But, if somebody, like we used to call it, when the spirit hits you and you feel like dancing, you just get up and dance —

MW: There you go.

HP: I knew a lady who would dance every Sunday. See it would just hit her and she'd feel so good she'd just walk from one end of the church to the other. And it was almost like it was on cue, because the preacher would go into that call and response thing. It's the same way I was saying, when the saxophone player used to go into the honking thing, with the jazz, it's almost the same thing.

MW: And you know sometimes when the preacher, when he says something that he knows is good, and he don't get the response he wants, he says, "uh y'all didn't hear me?"

HP: Yeah. He changes the grammar, he changes the inflection of it, the whole change of everything. And it's almost a quality that we don't have in political speakers now. It's like, I think the only guy that I could say could really do that now, would be Jesse Jackson. Martin Luther King had it.

MW: He sure did.

HP: And some of the great orators past. I bought a book of speeches, but these were just great speakers up to the 60's, and they all had that fire, you know, you go back to some of the

Roosevelt speeches, Churchill, Winston Churchill, the way they could speak to the guy on the lowest level, and to the person on the highest level, and they had that ability to change vocabularies, change words, and use inflections that would influence either crowd. And a musician has to do that too in a certain sense, by learning to read his audience. And sometimes your audience is deceptive. You know you get a bunch of people in tuxedos and you gear your music to a certain way. And that's not really what they want to hear, you see, they want to get down. And then you get another group of people who are just look like your average everyday worker, and they want to hear something a little above them. So sometimes you can misread your audience, the same way a speaker does. But that's, I guess that's a quality you gain over years.

MW: You know you mentioned changing inflection, and there's a concept that I teach in my classes called significant tone. In other words, from African American community, like if you went to a black Baptist or black Pentecostal church, and you got up to sing "Amazing Grace," and you sing it straight, and I heard this happen in a church one time, a girl got up and sang it straight cause she was worried about, oh, what will people think. And one of the deacons touched her on the arm and said, "look baby, we already know the melody."

HP: Yeah.

MW: "Now convince me that you know what grace is, come on, do something with that melody."

HP: Yeah, it's a certain authority that you have to have. You can hear that most of that, well I guess you call, well in the English language I guess there's words for all these things, indigenous cultures I guess, like country & western music. The lyrics to their songs are so basic and down to earth, you can't miss the message. Then you've got to do something with it. And then when they add the inflections and the tones that they use, you know, you know what they mean, it's just real. And I guess it's almost sometimes like the blues really, cause they use the same words. Like you said "y'all" and certain words that let you know that we are from the same place.

MW: Uh huh. A sense of community.

HP: Yeah.

MW: You know I was thinking of the blues for a tremendous emotional vehicle where the subjective qualities have to be exalted over the object of desire, cause it ain't but twelve bars.

HP: That's right, and as you said before, the emotion is first. And with jazz, in a lot of instances, the musicianship comes first. Now where my thing is, where I try to bring emotion and musicianship together, that's about where I am.

MR: Can you describe to some of our players that would be watching this, what kind of thought process, are you thinking chords and scales and all that when you play? Did your music education, did you have to kind of combine that with your instinct and come up with a —

HP: Yeah I had to come up with a formula. Basically with me emotion won out. There is a little, when you get into that, it's about 60/40, going in the way of emotion. But I would say too that some of the musicianship you acquire over the years too is inbred, I mean sooner or later it becomes in your subconscious. And sometimes your musicianship will not allow you to do certain things. And the way you've got to do that is you've got to somehow break those rules. Like Cecil Taylor.

MW: Uh huh. I was going to ask you that. Did you find yourself after you had studied technically, in trying to capture and define your voice the way you wanted to hear it, did you find that you almost had to break rules?

HP: Yeah. Well that's what jazz music is about really. Music is learning the rules, and then breaking them. That's the whole process.

[Pause]

MW: Let me just ask you to say, you say you found yourself breaking some of the rules. How did that sit with the people you were studying with? Did they understand that you had pursue that?

HP: Well no, I didn't do that then, no. I sort of kept the two separate. When I was studying I was studying, and then when I was playing I was playing. It was two different things. And then somewhere along the way they just were on a collision course. Because for a time you have to play within the rules, you've got to know them first. And then, but that's fine, that's fine you know, and you find your own voice, which every musician goes through.

MR: Was there a point in your career where you knew you were going to be a musician or something happened for you, or was it something like I always knew I was going to be a musician?

HP: No I didn't always know I was going to be a musician. It just happened, it just evolved that way. But the more I got into it the more I liked it, so that was just the way it happened.

MR: Tell us about what some of your earlier experiences were in trying to get into the jazz field, and was it a tough —

HP: Yeah, it was sort of tough. But I did something that very few people do, I formed a group immediately. I didn't play around with a lot of people, I just started a group. So that helped me a lot too, because I didn't have to play within anybody else's framework, I could, I started right out in mine. So it was rather hard, but that's what I did.

MR: You seem to like to organ trio format too, is that —

HP: Oh, yeah, I like the organ, but I use piano and bass, I've been using piano and bass now for about 8-9 years, but I still record a lot with the organ and I like recording with a lot of different formats.

MW: You know I feel like that Hammond B3 sound, just the sound of the instrument, is the perfect bridge between jazz, rhythm & blues and Gospel.

HP: That's right.

MW: Just the sound of the instrument.

HP: Yeah, well people too associate it with the church because you had it in the church, and then you bring that to jazz with the blues sound and the blues licks, and it's a perfect sound. And then it has a sustaining quality, where you can hold that chord, that's what I like about it, it has a nice sustaining quality. And then the organ bass line is another thing, with sort of a thumping sound.

MR: No fun to move them though.

HP: Yeah. There's some nice dancing sound, too, you know it gives a big heavy beat. So it's really conducive to a lot of things.

MR: Tell us about some of the great organ players you've worked with.

HP: Oh, boy, I've worked with them all. Charlie Earland, Jack McDuff, Sonny Phillips, Joey DeFrancesco, oh boy, Groove Holmes, Johnny Hammond Smith. Yeah. I've worked with a lot of organ players, and they were all good. They were the greatest. I also worked with Jimmy Smith, who is the king, so I worked with a lot of them.

MR: What's it been like visiting different parts of the country and other countries, have you done a lot of traveling and do you notice a difference in how people relate to your particular brand of music?

HP: Oh, well I'm well received everywhere. Surprisingly, you know a lot of people haven't heard, they've heard it but I guess they haven't really been aware of my kind of thing related to having a lot of blues in it. A lot of people ask you know, "how do you play like that?" or, "what kind of sound would you call that?" or, "what sort of style is that?" But I'm pretty well received, pretty well received. And in the States it's a nice audience. I love the audiences everywhere. A lot of people see a lot of difference in the audience, but you know a good audience is a good audience. I've gotten them in the States and abroad. But one thing I know too is traveling, a lot of people really don't know how beautiful America is, have never seen the country. That doesn't have anything to do with music, but I think culturally speaking, we really don't know how beautiful the country is, I mean to see all the sights. There's a lot there. A lot of people spend a lot of time going to other countries, and I think they should see their country first.

MW: In other words, some people say they always think the grass is greener, but you find out it's the angle of the sunlight.

HP: Right.

MW: You know I wanted to ask you to bring that thought home too is you know I find so much beauty in sounds that are produced in the African American community, though they are not in any music method book. You know I've never picked up a music method book and have someone tell you how to sing like Aretha Franklin.

HP: Oh, well you won't find that. No you won't find that. Well the one thing I can tell you is everywhere I go, I hear American music. Every country in the world, there'll be some form of American music. I was in Germany last week and I was just amazed, and they were playing some of the R&B and contemporary music, and you know, Barry White and all that, and man I was glad to hear that stuff. I was in a department store and they were just playing, The Manhattans, and Anita Baker, and all these people, then I went in another store and they were playing Horace Silver. In the airport they had all jazz, Horace Silver, Miles Davis, John Coltrane.

MR: In the airport?

HP: Yeah, just piped in. Then in the hotel they had you know, contemporary country & western music, crossing with contemporary R&B music, and I said, man, it's just amazing. And then it's amazing too to go back home and see how much people don't appreciate it.

MR: It's like our greatest export.

HP: Yeah. And we just take it for granted.

MW: Is there something that can be done to bring greater appreciation for the arts in general and for jazz in particular, to bring it to bear, and bring it to the mind of the American public, to say this is something that we have, that started here, that we can cherish and be more proud of and support in a greater way?

HP: Well you know I don't even limit it to music or art. I think we as Americans, and this has nothing to do with jazz or, as you say, it's art and jazz in particular, so I won't misquote you, but I think we've all hit, this is just my opinion, sort of a danger zone or we've got a crossroads where everybody's got to make decisions, and I think it all goes down to education. The whole key to everything is education. And everybody should be entitled to an education. You just can't educate a few and leave the rest out to swim, or hanging in the wind. Everything to me goes back to education. We don't teach geography in the schools anymore. So a kid only knows about his immediate area, sometimes his own block. In the meantime you take in New York City, when people haven't even been to a museum, and we've got more museums there than anywhere in the world on the face of the earth. You've got more culture in Manhattan Island, and you take ninety percent of

the people, and that's elaborate, I'm elaborating, cause I don't know I'm not a statistician, you know, but most of the people haven't been to a museum or a play, a ballet, anything. So you get everybody computer literate, and then send them way across the world to Japan, they know nothing about the culture. So then you find us in trouble with our nation, because nobody knows the culture. So I mean now you've got a trade war with them, and we don't even understand their culture. It's crazy. You take geography out, you take art, all the arts out — that's the only way you can expand your mind is through art — you take that out, they even take sports out, they just take everything out, and those are the ones they think people don't need, and those are the ones you need the most. One has to do with your physical well being, one has to do with your mental well being, and they're gone. It's crazy. So nobody knows nothing about any, nobody knows anything about anybody. So you wind up taking everything for granted. Your art, and I would dare say in America people even take their freedom for granted. We don't know what it is to be free. I mean really, when you really look at it. We can't even understand an artist expanding, you know going to war, breaking barriers. We do, we take it for granted. I wouldn't even eliminate us, but we travel, so we do know. You go to other countries and you see the limitations and the censorship and everything. Then it hits home. But how many people have the opportunity to travel? So those that don't you get it through education, and then it's not there. So we don't educate in the formative years, then we send them off to college, then they see all these things, it's just banging your head up against a brick wall, it's crazy. It's madness. So that's why I say that we are at a crossroads and we as adults have to make some big decisions, what we actually want, especially now, in the wake of Oklahoma City, now everybody's talking about wanting to give up some of the freedoms just to have a little peace. It's dangerous. And it all affects art, in one way or another.

MW: I was going to ask you that, because you know I'm of the opinion, and I just want to get a thought from you on this. I'm of the opinion that I don't think if the person who planted that bomb, the same morning he did that, had sat down and listened to a Mozart symphony or a good album side by Ellington, I don't think he could have put that bomb there.

HP: That's what I was talking about, getting everybody computer literate with no compassion. Cause there's no art. I went to a movie, I saw a movie, Martin Sheen was in it, I don't remember what it was, but it was about he was making a statement about teachers. And one teacher liking Shakespeare and Mozart, and Martin Sheen answers, say, "well I'm not worried about him 'cause as long as he does that he'll have compassion." You know he was talking about the science, of this guy who was in science, but he still listened to Mozart, and he says, "you don't have to worry about him, because he'll always be

compassionate." See and as long as we have balanced individuals and a balanced approach to life and education, I mean it still requires our science and math students to study art, then there will always be compassion around, and nobody will get overboard in one thing in a so-called specialized society where we have people who just do this, that's all they do. You know like somebody's attempt to stay like with a computer like 12 or 14 hours, and really just have a ball man. There's something wrong with that. There's something wrong with that, when they don't care about going out and hearing some music or anything. You know I can just, whatever happens, I can get it out of my computer.

MR: Well I think technology is always a double edged sword, because it brings all this wealth of information at your fingertips, but at the same time it makes people less likely to explore things on their own, to go out, as you say, and see live art, to see it being done by real people.

HP: Yeah, because I was at a candy counter one day, and I was buying some candy. And I asked the girl, she said, "what would you want, a half or a quarter?" And I said, "no just give me an eighth. "And she was bewildered. And the computer just wouldn't and it was so sad, until I bailed her out, I said, "well let me have a half a pound." I almost cried, and she was such a beautiful, friendly child, and didn't know anything without the calculator. It was just — that's sad. That's the danger of technology, when you have to rely on a machine. How do you survive? Like you call somebody and they say, "well our computers are down," I mean it's helpless. I mean the lights went out at Newark Airport, and it threw a whole country off. Do we need that? Do we really need that? And, you've got musicians now writing music with computers, you know guys just go in a room and "I've got my computer." And I don't need all that. Sometimes you know you're glad your time is almost over, man, because I don't need all this sometimes, I'll just pass on all that.

MW: There's some things you can not digitally sample.

HP: Oh, yeah, that's right.

MW: You know, I was thinking they have all these digital samples —

[pause — extensive overhead announcement — ship's captain's report.]

MW: I wanted to just ask you a couple of other things. Have you had occasion to play with Count Basie or with Joe Williams?

HP: No.

[pause — overhead announcement — ship's dining room]

MW: I would like to ask you as we wrap up our interview here, if you would have a word of encouragement or insight to younger or college age students, some involved in music, some perhaps at a liberal arts college, if you could give them some insights just about the nature of jazz or how to listen and appreciate the music.

HP: Gee.

MR: In 25 words or less.

HP: You know after all this, you really stump me. I just feel there are so many facets of it, if they just go out and hear artists that are appearing in the local area, and get, as I say, everyone should take a course in basic music appreciation. Do they still have those in school?

MR: They do.

HP: Yeah, I think everybody should be required to take that. And that way I think too, via the classroom they have a better chance of hearing it. I think my experience is that when they're exposed to it, they like it, any form of culture. And I also would say that one shouldn't cast one sort of music away. People should expand their appreciation. There's nothing wrong with hip hop, nothing wrong with rap, nothing wrong with none of it. It's just that there are different alternatives at different times, other music will serve a different purpose. I listen to it all, and enjoy it all. Just one should expand, then you don't have to throw one away. If I go see the symphony that doesn't mean I'm never going to listen to jazz again; if I hear jazz that doesn't mean I'm not going to hear a symphony or this. It just means that more expansion contributes to being a better balanced person. And that's what my thing is about — balance.

MR: Sounds good.

HP: And get that education.

MW: This is been an interview for the Hamilton College jazz archive with Houston Person. And thank you.

MR: Thank you.

HP: You're welcome.